

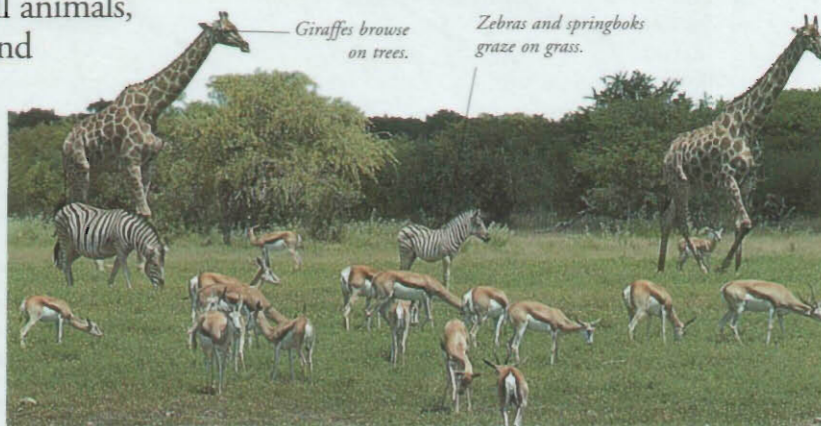
GRASSLAND WILDLIFE

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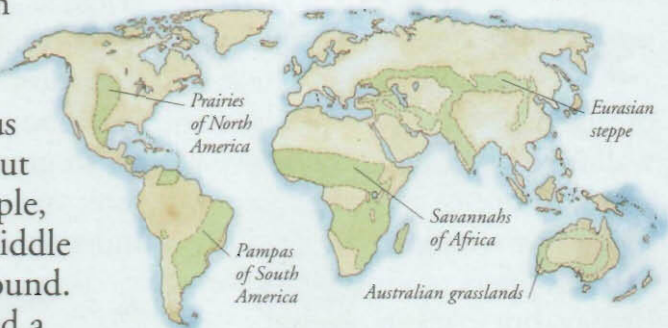


GRASSLANDS SUSTAIN MORE ANIMALS than any other type of land habitat. This is because each species eats a different type, or part, of the grass. In this way, the various species of herbivore can share the same habitat without competing for food. On the African plains, for example, zebras eat the tops of grasses, wildebeest prefer the middle layers, while Thomson's gazelles graze close to the ground. Tall grasses also provide shelter for myriad insects, and a refuge for small animals, such as birds and rodents, many of which live in burrows due to the lack of shelter from trees.

Giraffes, springboks, and zebras grazing on the African savannah



The world's major grasslands are shown, marked in green on the map below.



Grasslands

Grasslands cover 25 per cent of the Earth's land surface. The world's principal grasslands are the Eurasian steppe, the savannahs of Africa, the pampas of South America, the prairies of North America, and the Australian grasslands. Grasslands are areas where it is too dry for many trees to grow, but tough grasses grow in abundance. Grasses can withstand constant grazing by animals, and recover quickly from damage by fire, flood, or drought.

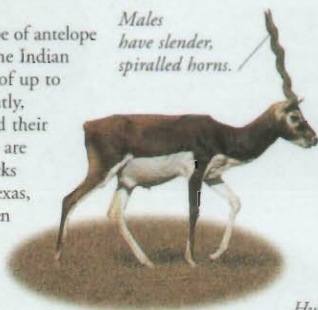
Mammals

Grasslands sustain a wide variety of mammals, mainly herbivores, often in large numbers. The herbivores support a population of carnivores, while scavengers, such as hyenas, jackals, and vultures, dispose of their remains. Typical grassland mammals include zebras in Africa; prairie dogs and coyotes in North America; maned wolves in South America; marmots in Eurasia; and kangaroos in Australia.

Blackbuck

Blackbucks are a type of antelope that once roamed the Indian grasslands in herds of up to 10,000. More recently, hunting has reduced their numbers, and there are now more blackbucks in Argentina and Texas, where they have been introduced, than in their original homeland.

Males have slender, spiralled horns.



Patagonian hare

The Patagonian hare, or mara, looks like a hare but is closely related to the guinea pig. It lives in burrows in groups of 30–40, in the Argentinian pampas and the stony Patagonian desert.

Long, thin legs help hare run fast.



American bison

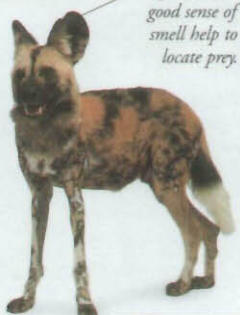
The most characteristic animal of the Great Plains of North America, the bison once numbered 50–60 million. By the 1880s, the huge herds had been almost destroyed by hunting. Only 500 remained, but given protection, numbers rose to 25,000. The bison now live in herds of up to 50 animals.



African wild dog

The wild dog lives in packs of up to 12 on the open savannahs of Africa. It employs a very effective method of communal hunting: having singled out an animal, such as a zebra or gazelle, from the herd, a pair of dogs chases it until they are tired, when a fresh pair takes over. Relays of dogs continue in this way until the prey is exhausted, and the pack closes in for the kill.

Huge ears and good sense of smell help to locate prey.



Invertebrates

Invertebrates are of great importance in tropical grasslands. They feed on dead vegetation, helping decompose it, and make nutrients available to plants. They also bring subsoil to the surface, helping to keep the soil healthy.

Ant lion

Ant lion larvae build pits in sandy soil and wait at the bottom for an ant or spider to dislodge grains of sand. Once alerted, the larva squirts sand at its victim, making it slide into the pit where the ant lion seizes it in its powerful jaws.



Dung beetle

Dung beetles roll dung into balls, which they lay eggs in, and push into holes. The larvae hatch and feed on the dung.



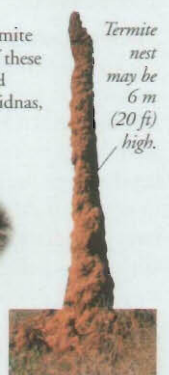
Termites

Tropical grasslands are dotted with termite nests, each containing several million of these insects. Termites are an important food source for many animals, especially echidnas, numbats, aardvarks, and pangolins.



Queen termites have huge, swollen bodies and can lay up to 30,000 eggs a day.

Termite nest may be 6 m (20 ft) high.



Pairs of African wild dogs run down animals larger than themselves.